

An R22 prototype
in flight in 1975

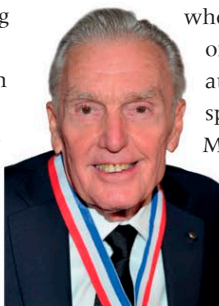


Great Manufacturers Robinson

Frank Robinson founded his own helicopter company in 1973 with the express purpose of designing and building a light helicopter for the masses. More than 4,500 of the R22 and 5,000 of the R44 have been sold worldwide. By the end of 2011 the company was producing more aircraft than any other helicopter manufacturer.

THE ROBINSON Helicopter Company is the result of one man's wish to bring rotary-wing flight within reach of the masses, realizing the dream of having a helicopter at home. The man with that dream was Frank Robinson, born on Whidbey Island, Washington, USA in 1930. Armed with an engineering degree from the University of Washington and his graduate work in aeronautical engineering at the University of Wichita, Robinson began his career in 1957 at the Cessna Aircraft Company, working on the company's first helicopter, the CH-1 Skyhook.

The only helicopter ever built by Cessna, the CH-1, originated in a design by Charles Siebel, who had joined Cessna as chief helicopter engineer in 1952. Siebel had a similar dream as Robinson, and thought that marrying Robinson's engineering knowledge with Cessna's flair for developing light aircraft could produce the goods. By 1957, when Robinson joined the team, the CH-1 was already in limited production as a military



Frank Robinson
(1930-)

helicopter, but was abandoned by Cessna in 1962. Robinson had by then moved on to manufacturer Umbaugh, where he worked for 12 months on a two-seat U-17/U-18 autogyro. He went on to spend four years at the McCulloch Aircraft

Corporation doing design work on the J2 autogyro. All of this experience was with private rotorcraft on a small scale. By 1969 Robinson had added Kaman Aircraft and Bell

Helicopter to his rotary-wing CV, before joining the Hughes Helicopter Company in California to work on various projects, including a new tail rotor for the successful Hughes 500 turbine helicopter. At this point, all his experience led Robinson to sketch out his own ideas for a light two-seat helicopter. Convinced of its potential but with his employer showing no interest, he resigned from Hughes in 1973 and set up his own company.

The Robinson Helicopter Company began life in Robinson's home, where his design, the R22, was developed over the next two years. The prototype was built in a rented hangar at Torrance Airport, south of Los Angeles, and Frank flew it himself on its first flight in August 1975.

From the beginning the R22 incorporated lessons learned from the earlier rotorcraft. Its features included

Flying school

Robinson-designed helicopter safety courses are the benchmark for the industry and are recommended around the world for anyone flying a Robinson helicopter.

“Keep it as simple as you can. Simplicity allows you to keep the cost down and reliability up.”

FRANK ROBINSON

a two-blade main and tail system for easy storage, a well-established piston engine running on commonly available aviation gasoline, a two-seat cabin, a light but structurally sound fiberglass and aluminum airframe, and a multitude of safety features, including an automatic throttle adjuster for when the collective pitch control was raised or lowered. This reduced the risk of losing rotor speed in flight, which could be catastrophic. Another novel feature unique to Robinson was the central T-bar cyclic stick. This allowed either front-seat occupant to fly the helicopter and avoided the individual sticks in front of each seat that were awkward to negotiate on entry and exit. The T-bar cyclic became a Robinson trademark that has been used in every Robinson helicopter ever since.

R22 production began at Torrance in 1979 and the little helicopter was an instant success, although not quite in the way Robinson had intended. Training schools soon found that the R22 was economical to use for all helicopter pilot training. This quickly became a big market, although initially it also resulted in a higher number of accidents, and a number of publicized fatalities. Robinson countered this with their own safety

courses for pilots and instructors, which are now used around the world, and improvements to the basic helicopter. The company also insisted that after 2,200 hours of customer use each helicopter be returned to the factory for a rebuild.

With the R22 well established, in the late 1980s Robinson began work on a new model. He realized that R22 owners, especially those with families or business interests, would want to



R44 with floats

The four-seat R44 was launched in the early 1990s and is used around the world today. This example has floats and can be used on water or land.

